portraits—as well as impressionistic works such as 'Reminiscence of a Dream-I' (1969) and a series of rare oils (Chowdhury hasn't really favoured this medium) called 'Representative from Hell'. In these works, you can see his mature style emerging from the figurative wanderings and experiments of the preceding decade.

"There are a lot of works here which show off my draughtmanship," Chowdhury said, "but technique can only get you so far, it cannot make you an original. Creativity never reverts to anything or follows a particular school or movement. It is like a coil, it has a central element, but nothing goes back to the centre, it flows outwards depending upon the capacity of the artist."

This exhibition is a measured walkthrough into Chowdhury's vast body of work. Amidst the many paintings, there are also Chowdhury's sketchbooks from every phase in his life—art school in Bengal, the Europe years, his time working at the Rashtrapati Bhavan in the 1980s. *Into the Half Light & Shadow Go I* also gives us some stellar recent works, paintings he made across 2019–2023. A lot of these feature predatory animals, monstrous half-man, half-animal hybrids. There are claws and talons, bared fangs and ripping flesh. With a smile, Chowdhury explained, "As an artist, I am always affected by and responding to the social reality around me, so these images of violence and, as you mention, predatory animals, are a reflection of that reality." ■

Aditya Mani Jha

(Into the Half Light & Shadow Go I *is on at Bikaner House, New Delhi, from March 8 to April 2)*

FASHION

AN ODYSSEY WITH ISSEY

Creations by Japanese fashion designer ***Issey Miyake*** *that were handpicked by an ardent admirer over three decades can be seen in an exhibition in Mumbai*

If design delights you, 47-A in Mumbai's iconic Khotachiwadi is probably already on your radar. The space was founded by designer-curator Srila Chatterjee's Baro Market and C&L Design from the art gallery Chatterjee & Lal, and has had some very interesting shows in its first year of operation. The latest, titled *Clothes That Changed the World*, has been curated by architect Ratan J. Batliboi and features clothes by legendary Japanese designer Issey Miyake, whose construction can almost be called architectural.

The show delves into one woman's odyssey with Issey. The late Mina Krishnan, a businesswoman, was enchanted by the freedom that the label represented and collected a number of Miyake pieces over three decades. After her demise last year (coincidentally the same year that Miyake passed away), her husband and daughter decided to share the garments so that more people could enjoy them. A few are on sale, the proceeds of which will go to Child Rights and You (CRY).



Issey Miyake believed in 'monozukuri', his own way of doing things



Photographs by PRIYA PATHIYAN

A visit to the ground-floor gallery ensconced in a warm-toned, Portuguese-style bungalow transports you to a different universe of cool, Zen-like sensibilities. On the right, a timeline displayed in Miyake's almost origami-like folding aesthetic gives a glimpse into his design story. On the left, we join Mina in her journey with Miyake, understanding the processes behind the pieces and the designer's inventions that, with a career spanning 45 years, changed the way the world perceived fashion. They say Miyake believed in 'monozukuri', his own way of doing things.

A walkthrough of the 'exhibits'—some limited-edition, vintage pieces from his signature Issey Miyake label, some outfits from his 'Pleats Please' and '132 5.' lines—reveals Miyake's work as almost-maximalistic fashion which is, ironically, all about minimalism and monochrome. For example, the hues may be quiet and the lines neat, but the plethora of pleats in his patent 'Pleats Please' range exudes an exuberance that others could possibly accomplish only with brash colours or loud prints.

Miyake was master of the seemingly uncut, untailored garment. But when you examine each one up close, you see the expertise that has gone into creating that ebb and flow of fabric, or a three-dimensional, almost mathematical, form that appears simple but has a complexity that grows on you. A piece of cloth is not just a piece of cloth when it's from his 'A Piece of Cloth' line, which is a tube-like creation that can be democratised—anyone can cut it and adapt it according to their own mood and muse, and wear it how they see fit.

Miyake was a fashion designer who wanted to design for 'everyone', using polyester instead of silk, presenting his clothing on catwalks modelled by people who didn't 'fit' the stereotype, long before other designers went woke. Miyake also believed that the best kind of sustainable fashion was when his 'seasonless' creations would be worn again and again. With this show, his legacy lives on with the warp and weft of Mina's own memories woven in. ■

Priya Pathiyan

(Clothes That Changed the World *can be viewed at 47-A, Khotachiwadi, Mumbai, until March 30)*